

Justification of violence, ideological preferences, and exposure to protests: causal evidence from the 2019 Chilean social unrest

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We examine the relationship between proximity to actively policed protest events and people's willingness to justify violence against police forces. Focusing on the Chilean social uprising, a series of massive protests between 2019 and 2020, this study highlights the significant implications of law enforcement issues on government legitimacy and the potential for protest policing to escalate violence. To conduct our research, we use a difference-in-differences design that combines survey data with georeferenced data on protests that experienced active policing near survey respondents. Our results show that spatial and temporal proximity to such protests significantly increases people's willingness to justify violence. Additionally, this effect is not uniform across all ideological groups. Exposure to protests with active policing strongly affects centrists, whereas it is negligible for leftists, rightists, and independents. Different robustness checks largely support a causal link between proximity to actively policed protests and justification of violence against the police. These insights contribute to our understanding of how mass mobilizations and state responses influence public attitudes, emphasizing the nuanced impact of protest policing on different ideological segments of society.

Key words: protests; procedural justice; attitude change.

Introduction

For decades, social movement scholars paid little attention to public opinion dynamics. This changed recently as studies showed that mass mobilizations and street protests can shape social and political attitudes. Research has examined their impact on political engagement (Pavlic 2021; Ketchley and El-Rayyes 2021; Wallace, Zepeda-Millán, and Jones-Correa 2014; Xu and Guo 2023;

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Pop-Eleches and Way 2021), electoral preferences (J. Muñoz and Anduiza 2019; Wasow 2020), policies (Curtis 2022; Enos, Kaufman, and Sands 2019), and views of protests (Ayoub, Page, and Whitt 2021).

We contribute to the literature by examining how active protest policing shapes public attitudes toward police, using the 2019–2020 Chilean social uprising as a case study. The protests, driven by discontent with inequality and political disconnect (Somma et al. 2021), prompted a violent police response that caused thousands of injuries, including 460 eye trauma cases (INDH 2020; Gajardo et al. 2022; Rodríguez et al. 2021). This triggered debates on policing, protest radicalization, and police-citizen relations, culminating in the impeachment of the Interior Minister (Bonner and Dammert 2022; El Mostrador 2020; Gerber et al. 2023).

We examine how proximity to protests with active protest policing practices, including the use of force, affects individuals' willingness to endorse violence during demonstrations. This inquiry is crucial as it explores the potential for a cycle of violence to be perpetuated among protestors, amplifying conflict (Goodwin 2001). Additionally, our findings could shed light on broader societal impacts, including how such dynamics may erode the perceived legitimacy of law enforcement and political institutions, reflecting citizens' grievances (Davenport 1995; Daxecker and Hess 2013).

This study offers three key contributions to understanding the attitudinal effects of protest policing. First, it broadens the scope of existing research by examining how spatial and temporal proximity to protests affects views on the legitimacy of violence against police—an underexplored topic. Second, it uses a causal inference strategy, combining panel survey data with georeferenced protest events to isolate policing's effect on attitudes. Third, it evaluates how responses vary by political ideology—left, center, right, or unaffiliated. Together, these elements form a doubly robust difference-in-differences (DiD) design (Sant'Anna and Zhao 2020) to assess ideology-specific, causal impacts of proximity to protest policing.

Our findings show that proximity to actively policed protests affects attitudes with both temporal and spatial variation. Temporally, the effect fades gradually over time. Spatially, it is nonlinear, with the strongest values at 2 km and 6 km, but weaker at 4 km. We also find that responses vary by ideology, with centrists showing a notable increase in justification of violence against police. While our design supports a causal link between protest policing and attitudinal shifts, isolating this from general protest exposure is complex. Still, supplementary analyses suggest policed protests have a stronger impact than non-policed ones, lending partial support to our hypothesis about the distinct effect of policing.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows: We begin by theorizing about the effects of protest proximity on attitude change—specifically, attitudes about justifying violence toward the police. Next, we briefly contextualize the social uprising and then describe our research design and empirical estimates. The last section summarizes our results and considers their broader implications.

Protest policing

Protesters often disrupt the political order, prompting authorities—even in democracies—to use police forces to constrain collective action (Jämte and Ellefsen 2020, 383). Social movement scholars refer to this as “protest policing,” encompassing law enforcement strategies to manage, control, or suppress demonstrations (Earl and Soule 2006; Della Porta and Reiter 1998). These actions range from communication and negotiation to confrontation and arrests (Nägel and Nivette 2023, 76). We use the term “protest policing” to describe this spectrum of responses, as it is more neutral than “repression” (Della Porta and Fillieule 2004).

The literature identifies two broad types of protest policing: “tough” versus “soft” (Della Porta and Fillieule 2004) or “escalated force” versus “negotiated management” (McPhail, Schweingruber, and McCarthy 1998). Building on these, we distinguish between “active” and “passive” protest policing. Active policing involves a more interventionist, often coercive approach—such as crowd control, protest dispersion, or use of force. In contrast, passive policing is more restrained, focusing

on monitoring, negotiation, maintaining order, and enabling democratic rights without direct intervention.¹

Once seen as a pathological response to mobilization (Kornhauser 1998; Smelser 1962), protest policing is now viewed as a strategic tool for maintaining social order (Davenport 2007; Tilly 1995). Active policing was more common a century ago, before the institutionalization of labor movements. Since the 1950s, expanding rights in Western democracies encouraged more dialogic policing (Della Porta and Fillieule 2004, 220). However, this shift was not linear—police responded harshly to disruptive protests in the late 1960s United States (Earl and Soule 2006, 582) and early 2000s anti-neoliberal movements. Protest policing also varies cross-nationally: it is more active in continental Europe than in Britain (Della Porta and Fillieule 2004), in Italy than Germany (Della Porta 1995), and in Latin America (Ortiz 2015) or China (Johnston and Zhang 2020) than in the West.

Protest policing influences demonstrator behavior in various ways. Targeted policing can fragment movements (Koopmans 1993), escalate protests (Francisco 1995; Koopmans 1993), or quell emerging protest cycles (Muller and Weede 1990). Its effects also reach the broader public: approval may rise when policing targets widely disapproved groups (Ellner 2003), but legitimacy can decline—and even lead to impeachments (Pérez-Liñán 2007)—if actions are seen as unfair (Franklin, Mackie, and Valen 2009). These mixed outcomes highlight the context-dependent nature of policing's societal impact. Electoral security plays a role: governments with strong majorities are more likely to use active protest policing (Aytaç, Schiumerini, and Stokes 2017).

Protest policing shapes public perceptions not only about the government but also about the police. Existing studies have focused on the link between procedural injustice and attitudes toward violence in protests (Gerber and Jackson 2017; Maguire et al. 2018, 2021; D. H. Tyler et al. 2018; Gerber et al. 2023). However, research on protest policing's effects on mass attitudes toward the police is scarce. We contribute to this topic below.

Protest proximity, procedural justice, and justification of violence in protests

Combining survey and protest event data with Geographic Information Systems has advanced our understanding of how protest proximity shapes political attitudes. This approach reveals that spatial closeness to protests can increase sympathy for activist demands, support for demonstrations, and political engagement (Disi Pavlic 2021; Wallace, Zepeda-Millán, and Jones-Correa 2014). However, other studies suggest proximity may also undermine protest legitimacy, fuel disaffection, and reduce support (Ketchley and El-Rayyes 2021; J. Muñoz and Anduiza 2019; Wasow 2020), highlighting the complex role of spatial context in shaping public opinion.

Our analysis examines the link between experiencing policed protests and attitudes toward police, using the “procedural justice” framework, which evaluates the fairness of law enforcement actions (T. R. Tyler and Blader 2000). This concept shapes public views of police authority, including the justified use of force. Positive perceptions of procedural justice are associated with greater acceptance of police violence and less support for aggression against officers. Drury and Reicher (2018) and Saavedra and Drury (2019) show that interactions with police can lead protest participants—especially nonviolent ones—to justify violence as self-defense or retaliation against perceived injustice. This framework highlights how perceptions of fairness influence public support and protest-related attitudes.

Perceptions of procedural injustice among protesters are linked to negative views of the police, disobedience (Perry 2020), and greater likelihood of justifying or engaging in violence (Maguire et al. 2018, 2021; Adam-Troian, Çelebi, and Mahfud 2020; D. H. Tyler et al. 2018). In Hong Kong, “a perception of low procedural justice contributed to increased public support for protestor violence by fostering identification with militant protestors” (Zhu and Chou 2024, 13). We extend this perspective to nonparticipants, who often differ from activists. While activists are typically highly committed, the broader public shows diverse attitudes toward protests, shaped by factors like proximity. This variation emphasizes the need to examine the wider societal effects of protest

policing, including ideological and cultural gaps between the public and demonstrators. In Chile, Gerber et al. (2018) show that perceptions of procedural justice and police legitimacy, shaped by group identity, significantly influence support for both police and protester violence.

Given evidence that proximity to protests shapes public opinion (Disi Pavlic 2021; Ketchley and El-Rayyes 2021; Wallace, Zepeda-Millán, and Jones-Correa 2014; Xu and Guo 2023; Pop-Eleches and Way 2021), we expect similar effects in contexts involving active policing. Studies in Chile show that unrest influenced attitudes toward both protester and police violence (Zbinden and Navia 2024; Carrasco Paillamilla and Disi Pavlic 2023). Thus, we hypothesize that closer proximity to actively policed events increases support for violence against law enforcement as a perceived form of protest. This contributes to understanding how policing experiences shape public views on violence and law enforcement in protest settings.

Hypothesis 1: *Proximity to protests with active policing during the October 2019 protest wave in Chile increases justification for violence against the police.*

Our research design does not allow us to test the specific mechanisms linking proximity to protests with our outcome. However, prior studies identify interconnected informational, psychological, and emotional pathways, offering useful insights. Physical vicinity can heighten the salience and accessibility of information, increasing awareness via local networks and media (Disi Pavlic 2021; Branton et al. 2015). Proximity acts as an “information revelation effect,” spotlighting underrepresented issues and shaping opinions through heuristics (Wallace, Zepeda-Millán, and Jones-Correa 2014; Tertychnaya and Lankina 2020). Protests can also make contentious issues more tangible through their impact on the local environment (Branton et al. 2015). Psychological and emotional mechanisms play a role as well: repeated exposure and familiarity reduce novelty and threat, fostering favorable views (Disi Pavlic 2021). Protests may activate shared identities and solidarity (Mazumder 2018) or function as symbols that convey grievances. Emotional responses—such as empathy from solidarity or alienation from violence—also shape attitudes. Nonviolent protests tend to elicit support, while violent ones may provoke fear and lead to more conservative views (Wasow 2020; Xu and Guo 2023). These mechanisms, though distinct, are complementary, underscoring the complex cognitive and emotional processes behind attitude formation in contentious contexts.

Ideology and justification of violence

Theoretical perspectives from social and political psychology highlight complex ideological dynamics. Individuals high in Social Dominance Orientation (SDO) or Right-Wing Authoritarianism (RWA) (Altemeyer 1998) may oppose violence against police, seeing it as a threat to order or authority.² Similarly, those with just-world beliefs (Lerner 1980) or prone to victim blaming (Ryan 1976) may view police actions as justified. By contrast, radicalization theory (Kruglanski et al. 2014) and reactance theory (Brehm 1966) suggest that active policing can fuel support for violence as a reaction to perceived injustice or loss of freedom. These divergent predictions underscore the need for further empirical research.

Following a motivated reasoning approach (Taber and Lodge 2006), we expect that individuals' pre-existing dispositions condition the influence of proximity to policed protests. This expectation aligns with the notion of the “prior attitude effect” (Taber and Lodge 2006), showing that people tend to pay more attention to and remember information that is consistent with their prior attitudes while being more likely to dismiss or forget information that is inconsistent with their priors. This can make it difficult for people to change their attitudes, even in the face of new evidence, leading to biased or distorted thinking.

We expect that support for the October social unrest will shape responses to active policing, with greater sympathy for the movement linked to lower tolerance for perceived unfairness. Although we lack direct measures of movement support, we use ideological self-placement as a proxy, assuming alignment between support for the left-leaning movement and left-wing positions, given the right-wing government context (Gonzalez and Le Foulon 2020, 230–31). In

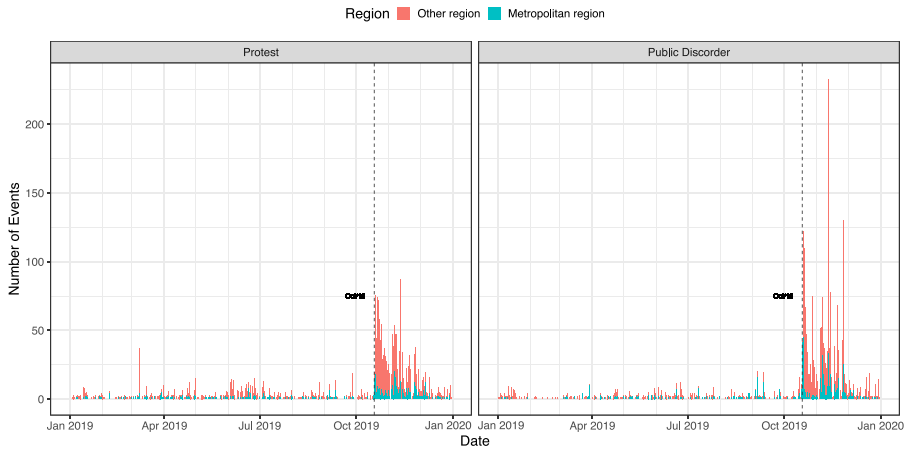


Figure 1. Protest and public disorder events before and after the October 2019 social unrest source: Observatory of Conflicts (COES 2020).

Chile, the left-right divide reliably captures political preferences (Harbers, de Vries, and Steenbergen 2013; Visconti 2021) and party system structure (Kitschelt et al. 2010; Martínez-Gallardo et al. 2022), even amid declining ideological identification (Bargsted and Somma 2016). We thus hypothesize that left-leaning individuals are more likely to perceive active policing as unjust due to ideological predispositions.

Right-wing individuals are unlikely to be affected by exposure to active policing, given their limited sympathy for protest movements and tendency to view police actions as justified, especially in response to violence (Gutting 2020). Traits linked to conservative ideologies—death anxiety, fear of instability, and a need for order—further support this view (Jost et al. 2003). Centrists, independents, or non-ideologues, lacking strong prior biases, may become more tolerant of protest violence after witnessing active policing, though likely to a lesser extent than leftists, who generally show greater initial sympathy and thus more potential for attitudinal change.

Hypothesis 2: *The effect of proximity to protests with active policing is conditioned by the ideological positions of the citizen on the left-right scale.*

H2a: *The effect of temporal and geographical proximity to protests with active policing is large and positive on those who identify with the left.*

H2b: *The effect of temporal and geographical proximity to protests with active policing is null on those who identify with the right.*

H2c: *The effect of temporal and geographical proximity to protests with active policing is less pronounced for individuals who identify with the political center than for those who identify as left-wing.*

H2d: *The effect of temporal and geographical proximity to protests with active policing is less pronounced for individuals who identify as non-ideologues than for those who identify as left-wing.*

Context: The October 2019 protest wave

In October 2019, Chilean students initiated mass protests against a subway fare hike in Santiago, leading to widespread unrest and the destruction of public infrastructure. These demonstrations quickly spread nationwide. President Sebastián Piñera responded by declaring a state of emergency and curfews, referring to the situation as a war against an “implacable enemy” (Deutsche Welle 2019). Despite military deployment, the protests expanded significantly, marking unprecedented levels of civil disorder in modern Chile. Figure 1 illustrates the surge in protests across the Santiago Metropolitan Region and the rest of Chile following the October 18 outbreak.

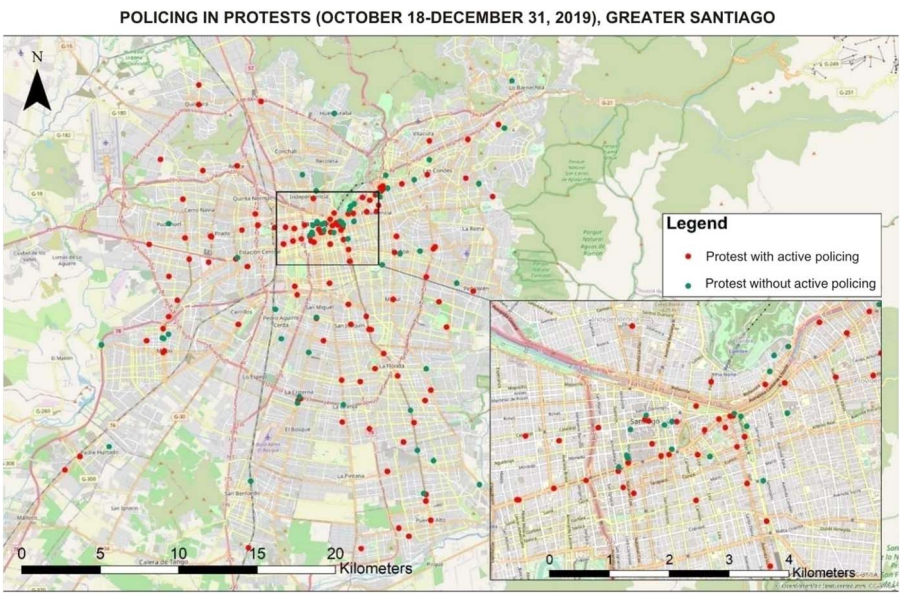


Figure 2. Geocoded map events with and without active policing in Santiago, Chile, October 18–December 31, 2019. Source: Authors’ elaboration based on [COES \(2020\)](#).

Despite the military’s deployment and the government’s war rhetoric, Chile’s social uprising evolved with tactics ranging from peaceful to violent. The October 25 march, dubbed “the largest in history,” saw nearly a million people peacefully protesting in Santiago, contrasting with daily violent episodes like bus burnings and clashes with police ([Paredes 2021](#), 38). Tensions peaked on November 15, as political parties agreed to a referendum for a new Constitution, yet unrest persisted, leading to 23 deaths by month’s end. Amidst ongoing protests, Amnesty International investigated police violence allegations, highlighting the complex dynamics between government responses and the evolving nature of the demonstrations.³

[Figure 2](#) maps Santiago’s protests from October to December 2019, distinguishing between actively policed (red dots) and other (green dots) events. It shows a dense cluster of largely unpoliced protests in central Santiago, in contrast to the outskirts, where protests are fewer and more often actively policed. In sum, this period featured a widespread, sudden, and varied protest wave across Chile, highlighting significant spatial disparities in how demonstrations were managed.

Study design

We build on recent studies that combine survey and protest event data to assess how proximity to active policing affects justification of violence against police. These studies use various methods to estimate causal effects. [Ketchley and El-Rayyes \(2021\)](#), for instance, use distance to protest sites in an instrumental variables design. Others, like [Curtis \(2022\)](#), apply propensity score matching to compare respondents before and after mobilizations. A “superior approach,” however, is using panel data with spatial buffers ([Ketchley and El-Rayyes 2021](#), 303). While some use panel data ([Pop-Eleches and Way 2021](#)) or spatial buffers ([Wallace, Zepeda-Millán, and Jones-Correa 2014](#)), we know only one work ([Xu and Guo 2023](#)) combining both to study protests’ causal effects on attitudes.⁴

To evaluate our hypotheses, we use a DiD design based on two waves from the Longitudinal Social Survey of Chile (ELSOC) panel survey data (which we describe below): the 2018 wave, which

was fielded ~1 year before the October movement, and the 2019 wave, whose fieldwork started one month after the intensive protest cycle started on October 18, 2019.

Following [Imbens and Wooldridge \(2009\)](#) the canonical DiD linear regression model corresponds to:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \eta \text{Wave}_t + \tau \text{Protest Exposure}_{it} + \mu_i + \epsilon_{it}$$

where $\text{Protest Exposure}_{it} = 1$ if respondent i was exposed to protests events with active policing in $\text{Wave}_t = 2019$, otherwise 0. μ_i corresponds to a survey respondent fixed effect, and ϵ_{it} is an independent and identically distributed error term. The parameter of interest, τ , captures the causal effect of proximity to protest events with active policing. The μ term is fundamental for causal inferential purposes because it accounts for unobserved temporally invariant heterogeneity and consequently helps to account for self-selection into the treatment ([Lechner 2011](#)). The η term is also a key element since exposure to protest events with active policing occurred in the middle of a grand-scale social movement in which many mobilizations took place nationwide. Thus, variations in levels of support for transgressive tactics between survey waves may be reactions to the bundle of political events that occurred after October 18. The η term can capture these variations for the entire sample, while the estimate of direct exposure to protest events with active policing, τ , accounts specifically for spatial proximity to protest events.

The canonical DiD linear model marked a significant improvement over strategies based solely on cross-sectional data. However, it has been subject to criticism, particularly for its reliance on strong modeling assumptions—most notably, the assumption of homogeneous treatment effects and, more crucially, the parallel trends assumption ([Imai and Kim 2021](#)). The latter requires that, in the absence of treatment, the treated group (those proximate to protest events with active policing) and the control group (those not proximate) would have exhibited similar trends over time. To temper this assumption, we adopt a Doubly Robust DiD estimator ([Sant'Anna and Zhao 2020](#)) This approach recovers treatment effect estimates under the conditional parallel trends assumption, meaning that treatment and control groups are assumed to follow similar trajectories over time after conditioning on observable covariates.

The Doubly Robust DiD model combines two refinements: the Regression Adjustment Model ([Heckman, Ichimura, and Todd 1997](#)) and the Inverse Probability Weighting scheme proposed ([Abadie 2005](#)). Both involve pre-processing data to ensure comparability between pre- and post-treatment groups before estimating within-subject differences. Regression adjustment models the expected outcome for untreated units and uses this to predict counterfactuals for treated ones. Inverse Probability Weighting balances groups by weighting observations based on treatment probability, given covariates. Crucially, the estimator remains consistent if at least one method is correctly specified. The covariates used in both components are described in the next section.

Data and Methods

We employ data from the ELSOC by the Centre for the Study of Social Conflict and Cohesion Studies ([COES 2024](#)) to test our propositions. This annual, anonymous face-to-face panel survey was conducted in Chile between 2016 and 2022. The baseline sample ($T_1=2016$) included 2927 adults aged 18–75 (60.27% females; Age = 46.10, SD = 15.28). The second wave ($T_2=2017$) included 2473 participants (62% females; Age = 47.6, SD = 15.28). The third wave ($T_3=2018$) included 3748 participants (61% females; Age = 47.1, SD = 15.5). Finally, the fourth wave ($T_4=2019$) sample included 2573 participants (63.5% females; Age = 49.3, SD = 15.5). The attrition rate from T_1 to T_4 was relatively low (26%).⁵

To gauge the impact of proximity to actively policed protests on public attitudes, we utilized the COES Conflict Observatory's database ([COES 2020](#)), which provides a detailed record of the protest events in Chile from 2009 to December 31, 2019. Protest event databases that rely on media reports inevitably exhibit biases. Media outlets selectively report protest events based on

perceived newsworthiness, often emphasizing intensity, violence, and conflict over peaceful or routine demonstrations, leading to editorial bias (Ortiz et al. 2005, 398). Additionally, newspapers tend to prioritize events in central, politically significant locations, creating geographic disparities (Hocke 1999). Variations across media formats further shape how protests are represented (Hutter 2014, 336).

While media coverage may correlate with protest visibility and policing style, the COES dataset includes safeguards to mitigate such biases. It compiles data from 18 media outlets (four national, 14 regional), helping reduce geographic bias, ensure editorial diversity, and limit political skew. It also incorporates various formats—print, digital, and radio—to balance the shortcomings of any one platform. Standardized coding procedures and regular inter-coder reliability checks further promote consistency. Finally, because the ELSOC sample is urban, the risk of underreporting rural protests—where media presence is lower—is minimized. Though no dataset is entirely bias-free, these features make COES a robust and reliable source for analyzing protest dynamics.⁶

This dataset allowed us to map protest locations against ELSOC respondents' census blocks, identifying those living near actively policed events.⁷ We define proximity as the temporal and geographical closeness of respondents' residences to protest events. The rationale is that those living near actively policed protests are more likely to experience these events directly or indirectly. As noted earlier, spatial proximity can shape attitudes even without direct exposure. Local networks, media coverage, and visible effects (like property damage or increased police presence) can influence perceptions. Similarly, emotionally charged conversations with peers and stress from disrupted routines may amplify or moderate criticism of police actions.

Our control group includes respondents from areas with no protests and areas with passively policed protests. While this might seem to conflate distinct groups, the decision aligns with our theoretical focus: evaluating whether exposure to actively policed protests affects justification of violence against police. Crucially, both control conditions lack the confrontational police behavior we argue triggers retaliatory attitudes. By contrast, active policing involves visible, potentially aggressive interventions that may be perceived as disproportionate or unjust—factors we hypothesize drive shifts in public attitudes toward law enforcement.

Despite our rigorous research design, data, and econometric methods, achieving unequivocal causal identification remains challenging. Distinguishing whether attitudinal shifts result from actively policed protests or broader protest exposure is complex. We have attempted to clarify this by analyzing non-policed protest events in our robustness section, as reported by our data source.⁸

We measured individuals' ideological positions using an 11-point self-location scale ranging from 0 = "left" to 10 = "right." This variable was recoded so that values from 0 to 4 indicate a left-wing preference, 5 indicates center or ideologically moderate, and 6 to 10 indicate affinity with right-leaning positions. Respondents who declined to place themselves on the scale were categorized as "independent" or "none" based on their spontaneous responses to the item. In both cases, they were classified as non-ideologues.

To measure respondents' level of justification of violence against the police in policed protests, we employ the following survey item: *To what extent do you think the following situations are justified or not? Students throwing stones at the police in a demonstration for education.*⁹ Responses were provided using a 5-point ordinal scale ranging from "Never justified" (coded 1) to "Always justified" (coded 5).

In addition to outcome, treatment, and moderating variables, we include several covariates for estimating the propensity score and for the regression adjustment in the Doubly Robust DiD model. The first set, measured at the census zone level, accounts for variation in protest frequency across locations. These include population density, number of young adults (15–24), percentage of female residents, mean years of schooling, and share of inadequate dwellings. These factors are linked to protest participation—through density (McVeigh 2006, 540), age (Disi Pavlic and Mardones 2019, 213; Roberts 2016, 144), gender (Disi Pavlic and Mardones 2019, 213; McAdam 1986), education (Castillo et al. 2015, 497; Roberts 2016, 144), and socioeconomic status (Brady,

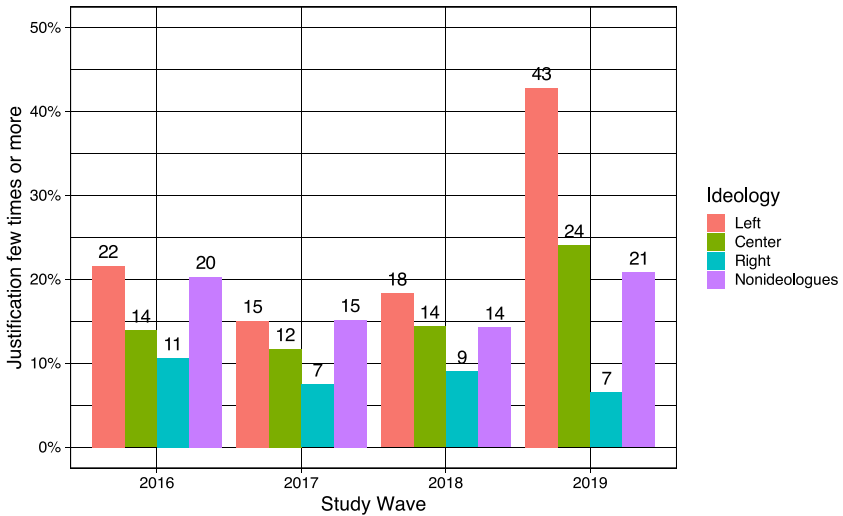


Figure 3. Justification of violence against the police by ideological preferences, 2016–2019. Source: Longitudinal social study (COES 2024).

Verba, and Schlozman 1995, 280; Roberts 2016, 144)—and may affect exposure to mobilizations. Controlling for these helps make treated and untreated groups more comparable, supporting the conditional parallel trends assumption in DiD models.

The second set of controls is measured at the individual level, as these factors may change differently over time between treated and untreated groups or exert time-varying effects on the outcome. We control for protest participation in the past 12 months, which may influence attitudes toward proximity to active protest policing. Additional covariates include gender, age, education, attitudes toward police¹⁰ and mobilization,¹¹ and interpersonal trust and interpersonal trust—factors shown to correlate with views on active policing and violence (Arthur and Case 1994; Gerber et al. 2023, 10; Gerber and Jackson 2017; Han, Sun, and Hu 2017; Jackson et al. 2012; Sunshine and Tyler 2003). We also control for media consumption frequency, as it is linked to support for punitive policies and police use of force (Roche, Pickett, and Gertz 2016). Lastly, we include RWA (Altemeyer 1998)¹² and SDO (Pratto et al. 1994),¹³ both associated with support for active policing and violence (Benjamin 2006; Krause 2022). All covariates are measured pre-treatment—for example, using 2018 data to assess 2019 effects.

Before applying DiD estimators to assess the 2019 Chilean uprising, we examine the link between ideological preferences and justification of violence against police (figure 3). ELSOC panel data show increased support for stone-throwing among centrists, nonideologues, and leftists in 2019, suggesting a possible connection between active policing and support for violence. In contrast, right-wing views remained stable, indicating that ideology shapes perceptions of protest legitimacy. This sets the stage for our DiD analysis of how ideology conditions support for violence against police.

DiD results

Figure 4 presents the ATET of our treatment—proximity to at least one actively policed protest—in nine different DiD models that combine our temporal and spatial nearness measures. ¹⁴ Sant’Anna and Zhao’s (2020) improved DR DiD estimators are implemented on Stata (StataCorp 2021) through the “drdid” command (Ríos-Ávila, Sant’Anna, and Naqvi 2021).

As figure 4 shows, the estimates of the effect of exposure to policed protests on willingness to justify the use of violence by demonstrators are positive and statistically significant for the whole

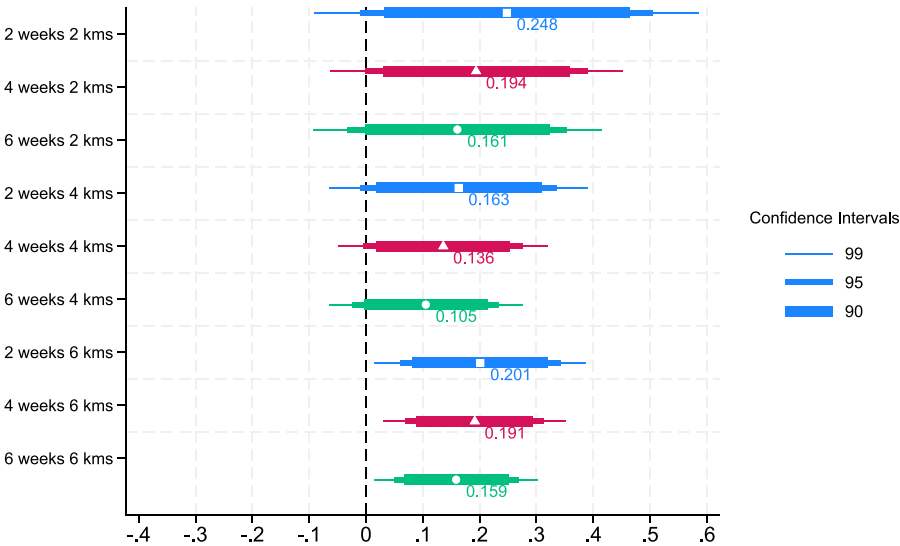


Figure 4. Effects of proximity to protests with active policing on justification of violence in mobilizations (2018–2019).

sample in seven of the nine spatial and temporal distance measures. In terms of magnitude, the impact of proximity to policed protests decreases over time, with our analysis showing a 35% reduction in effect from the second to the sixth week, assuming a constant two-kilometer distance. Spatially, the effect’s intensity varies non-linearly, being strongest at both the nearest (2 km) and farthest (6 km) distances but weaker at a medium distance (4 km). The largest impact occurs within two weeks and two kilometers from events with active policing, marking a substantial influence equivalent to a quarter of a standard deviation of the dependent variable.

The findings suggest that near (2 km) and far (6 km) events significantly influence attitudes with similar effect sizes across different time windows and even less statistical uncertainty for farther events. This suggests that proximity to and distance from protests with active policing—whether near or far—have a greater impact on attitudes than events at intermediate distances (4 km). However, the differences are far from significant.¹⁵

A potential—though admittedly ad hoc—explanation for the observed impact of active protest policing at both the closest (2 km) and farthest (6 km) distances may lie in typical daily commuting patterns. According to the most recent Origin–Destination Survey for Santiago, ~40 percent of daily trips, primarily for work or school, span between 5 and 7.5 kilometers, with an average Euclidean distance of 5.6 kilometers (V. Muñoz et al. 2015, 32).¹⁶ This average closely aligns with our 6 km buffer, suggesting that the significant effects detected at both ends of the spatial range may reflect respondents’ exposure not only near their residences but also along routes they frequently travel. This alignment between spatial buffers and daily mobility patterns lends indirect support to Hypothesis 1.¹⁷

Table 1 presents the results of exposure to protests with active policing for each ideological group separately. Proximity was measured using two weeks and a six-kilometer buffer. Multiple estimators suggested by the DiD literature, including the outcome regression, IPW, and DR estimators, were used to check the robustness of the results. The results show little variation in the magnitude of the estimates produced by the different estimators and no variation in the inferences drawn from them.

Our findings provide partial support for and partial departure from the hypothesized conditional effects of ideology. Among left-wing individuals, the effect of proximity to active policing

Table 1. Effects of proximity to protests with active policing on justification of violence in mobilizations, by ideology using six DiD estimators (2018–2019).

Estimator	Right	Center	Left	Nonideologue
DR IPW	−0.0872 (0.0993)	0.498* (0.214)	0.0500 (0.205)	0.192 (0.209)
DR Improved	−0.0700 (0.100)	0.496* (0.211)	0.0123 (0.208)	0.176 (0.208)
Outcome regression	−0.104 (0.107)	0.536* (0.210)	0.0583 (0.220)	0.0916 (0.208)
Abadie 2005 IPW	−0.0740 (0.0979)	0.471* (0.220)	0.0357 (0.204)	0.197 (0.215)
Standardized IPW	−0.0731 (0.0969)	0.477* (0.218)	0.0327 (0.200)	0.196 (0.212)
IPW and regression adjustment		0.496* (0.211)	0.0108 (0.210)	0.177 (0.208)
Observations	522	714	730	1130

Standard errors in parentheses. *** $P < .001$, ** $P < .01$, * $P < .05$, † $P < .1$. The IPW and regression adjustment estimator for the Right subsample could not be obtained.

is positive but small and not statistically significant: Hypothesis 2a is rejected. As expected, the effect is null for right-wing respondents, confirming Hypothesis 2b. By contrast, we are somewhat perplexed by the strong, positive, and statistically significant effect among centrists, more than double the average treatment effect and exceeding half a standard deviation of the outcome variable, partially supporting Hypothesis 2c. We also find a positive effect among non-ideologues, slightly larger than the average, but large standard errors (despite a substantial sample) lead us to reject Hypothesis 2d.

Although our results are robust to different measures of geographic and temporal distance and DiD estimators, there may be time-varying confounders confounding the impact of exposure to active policing during the 2019 unrest. The DiD design, as it accounts for time-invariant differences, may overlook time-dependent differences between the groups. In other words, our data may not meet the parallel trend or equal trends assumption (Huntington-Klein 2022, 441–49)—if widescale protests with active protest policing had not occurred, differences between exposed and unexposed groups would have remained the same before and after 2019.

Robustness analyses

In this section, we address the validity of two crucial assumptions underpinning the DiD analysis: the conditional parallel trends and excludability assumptions, which are essential for ensuring the reliability of our findings.

Since conditional parallel trends are counterfactual and thus unobservable, we conduct placebo tests to assess the plausibility of this assumption. Specifically, we replicate our analysis using data from the 2017 and 2018 waves of the ELSOC survey. These waves were collected under the same presidential administration and draw on the same panel and protest event datasets. Crucially, however, the 2017–2018 period did not feature widespread active protest policing, making it a suitable untreated comparison period. As shown in figure 5, the number of protests with active policing increased sharply after October 2019. Therefore, earlier waves did not expose respondents to similar levels of protest activity. If the placebo results resemble those of our main analysis, this would cast doubt on a causal interpretation. Conversely, null effects would strengthen the case that exposure to large-scale, actively policed protests in 2019 caused changes in the justification of violence against the police.

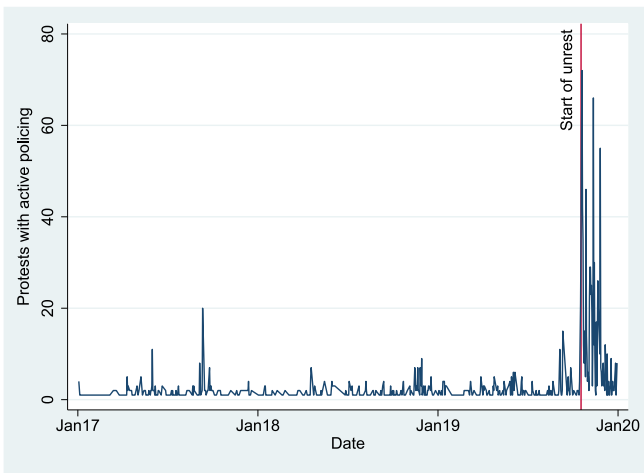


Figure 5. Frequency of protests with active policing in Chile, 2017–2019. Source: Authors’ elaboration based on the Observatory of Conflicts (COES, 2020).

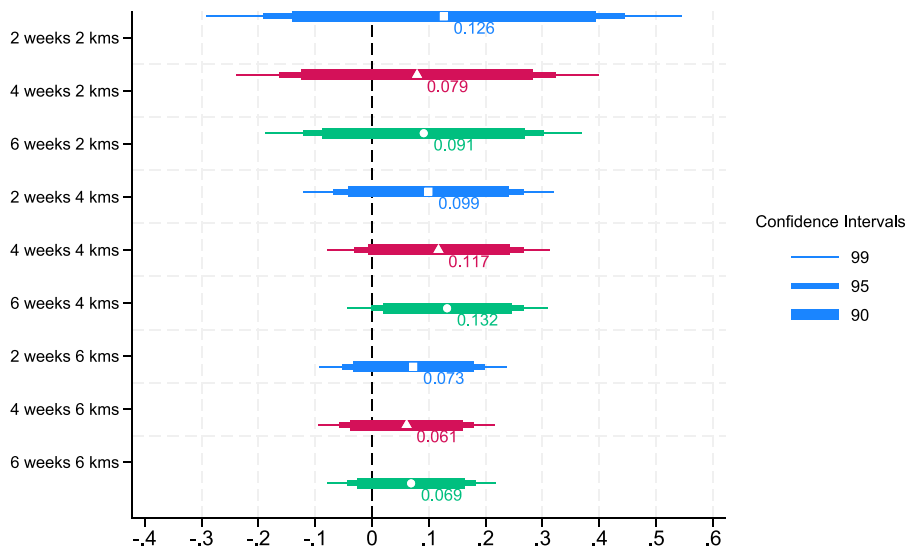


Figure 6. Effects of proximity to protests with active policing on justification of violence in mobilizations (2017–2018).

Figure 6 shows the results of the same models as the main results (Table 1) but for ELSOC respondents’ attitudinal changes between 2017 and 2018.¹⁸ In this case, the effect is null for all but one of the measures of proximity to actively policed protests (the 6 weeks–4 kilometers measure, $P < .1$). This finding broadly supports the assumption that any observed treatment effect of exposure to large-scale policing is due to the treatment itself rather than some other confounding factors.

Addressing the excludability assumption involves distinguishing the effects of proximity to actively policed protests from general protest exposure. Since exposure to active policing inherently includes exposure to demonstrations, and with a notable correlation ($r = 0.6$) between proximity to actively policed and other protests, isolating the unique impact of active policing

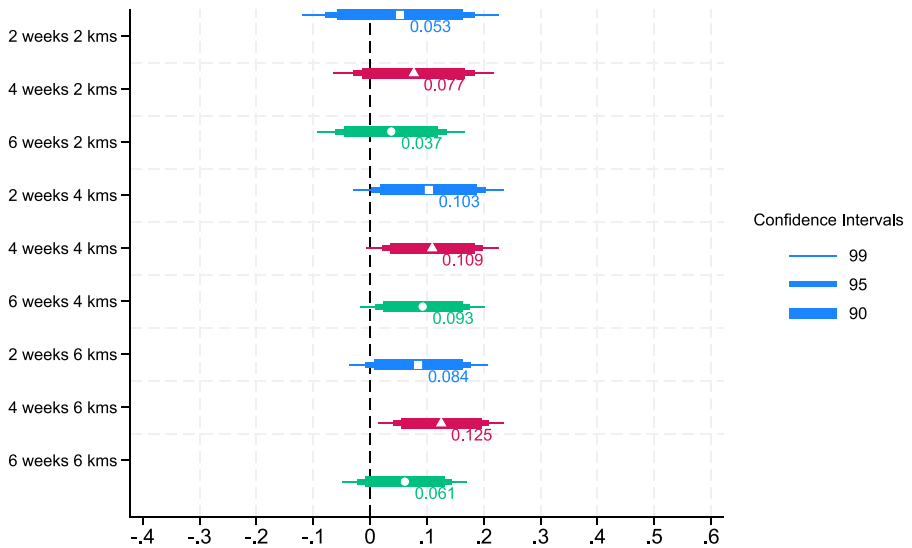


Figure 7. Effects of proximity to protests without active policing on justification of violence in mobilizations (2018–2019).

is challenging. However, supplementary analyses indicate that changes in attitudes towards law enforcement are more closely linked to experiences of active policing than to general protest participation.

Figure 7 compares coefficients for models analyzing the impact of proximity to non-policed protests using the exact model specification as figure 5. Two key observations stand out: first, the effects are consistently smaller across all time windows, such as a decrease from 0.248 to 0.057 for a 2-week window with a 2 km buffer, averaging a 49% reduction compared to active policing. Second, the linear time decay pattern present in figure 4 is not observed in figure 7, where effects across different temporal windows show slight variation or even increase over time, such as in the 4 km buffer. This suggests a more erratic impact pattern over time for non-policed events, deviating from the earlier linear decay trend.

Discussion and Conclusions

Traditionally, political science and sociology emphasized the direct impact of protests on policy. Tarrow (2011), for example, argues that protests can elevate politicians who become “tribunes of the people”. More recently, scholars have explored the indirect effects of protests, mediated by shifts in public opinion. This perspective suggests that protests can influence politics by reshaping attitudes, which then affect voting and other behaviors. One way to examine this is by studying how exposure to active protest policing alters public opinion.

Using an innovative DiD design that spatializes thousands of protests and panel survey respondents, we find that proximity to active protest policing increases anti-police attitudes, confirming our first hypothesis. The most pronounced shift occurs within two weeks and two kilometers of a policed event. This effect diminishes by about half when the interval extends to six weeks, highlighting the importance of spatial and temporal closeness. Placebo tests using 2017–2018 data and unpoliced protests show that only large-scale, actively policed events like those in 2019 significantly alter public justification of violence against police. Robustness checks broadly support a causal link. However, our design does not test the procedural injustice mechanism we propose.

Hypothesis 2 is only partially supported, revealing the complexity of the October 2019 protests. Left-wing respondents significantly increased their justification of violence against police from 2018 to 2019 (see [figure 4](#)), becoming more supportive of violent tactics during the unrest. This shift occurred regardless of direct exposure, suggesting that media coverage, particularly from alternative left-leaning sources ([Luna, Toro, and Valenzuela 2022](#), 5), may have shaped attitudes. The absence of change among ideological extremes supports the idea that “politically involved partisans are likely to have a larger amount of existing knowledge, which would render them less persuadable because any piece of new information would produce a relatively small impact on the mix of existing knowledge and considerations in their minds” ([Lee et al. 2017](#), 368). In short, exposure to active policing had no discernible effect on ideological extremes, who appear more resistant to attitude change.

Notably, centrists—who were less engaged with the October 2019 unrest—showed significant attitude shifts. [Zaller's \(1992\)](#) Receive-Accept-Sample (RAS) model helps explain this: centrists are less ideologically rigid and thus more open to messages from various perspectives. Their opinions are formed from a broader, more context-dependent pool of considerations. Unlike nonideologues, who may lack the engagement to register political cues, centrists are more attuned to the salience of events. As a result, they may have been particularly responsive to the emotional intensity of protests with active policing, explaining the large and statistically significant effect observed.¹⁹

Our findings help clarify the backlash effect of protest policing. Prior research shows that when governments are weak—marked by low approval or unstable electoral support—indiscriminate policing can escalate protests and erode legitimacy ([Aytaç, Schiumerini, and Stokes 2017](#); [Koopmans 1993](#)). Yet, it remained unclear which citizens were most likely to react. Our study addresses this gap: backlash is strongest among moderates, not those with strong pro- or anti-government views. In Chile, this effect was particularly evident among centrists, defined by their position between left and right ideologies.

In this respect, our study highlights the need to reevaluate the role of ideology's influence in social movement and collective action research. While survey-based studies often reduce ideology to a control variable or an indicator of political engagement ([Schussman and Soule 2005](#)), our analysis of Chile's uprising demonstrates that political ideologies significantly shape individuals' responses to protests and policing. This opens several critical questions: How do ideological orientations affect information processing on collective actions? Are groups like centrists or rightists typically less engaged and mobilized by large-scale protests than leftists are?

Additionally, our study demonstrates the effectiveness of integrating longitudinal panel surveys with data on critical events, such as social revolts, to evaluate the factors influencing changes in people's attitudes. As mass protests become more frequent and access to survey data grows, liberal democracies are a continuous laboratory for applying quasi-experimental techniques like difference-in-differences.

Grounded in general theory, our findings may offer insights into the effects of active policing beyond this case. Still, we recognize that contextual factors may limit generalizability. In Chile, elements such as the programmatic void in the political center, the Pinochet dictatorship's human rights legacy, and possibly harsher crowd control tactics may shape how our results travel. Comparative analysis with cases like the Umbrella Movement in Hong Kong, the Yellow Vests in France, or the George Floyd protests in the U.S. could help clarify these dynamics.

As noted, our dataset does not distinguish whether active policing during protests was initiated proactively by the state or reactively in response to demonstrator violence—a common limitation in protest event data. This ambiguity cautions against definitive interpretations but also opens key theoretical questions. Procedural justice theory ([Gerber and Jackson 2017](#); [Gerber et al. 2018](#)), suggests that if policing is viewed as a justified response to protest—an interpretation shaped by ideological priors ([Thompson, Metcalfe, and Pickett 2023](#))—its negative effect on public attitudes may be muted. Conversely, if bystanders see it as unprovoked, especially against peaceful demonstrators, the perceived illegitimacy may heighten criticism of the police. Our results likely reflect both dynamics, which we cannot disentangle given current data constraints.

This gap could be addressed through two strategies. First, qualitative research could examine the cues and interpretive frameworks people use to assess policing, building on recent work (Thachil 2020; Ellefsen 2021). Second, experiments could expose participants to images or videos of policing in two settings: (1) reactive responses to protester provocations, and (2) unprovoked actions against peaceful demonstrators. Follow-up attitudinal measures would assess how these framings shape public evaluations of police (see Curtice 2021; Curtice and Behlendorf 2021).

Our findings also suggest avenues for future research. Our dependent variable focuses on a specific tactic (stone-throwing), demand (education), and actor (students). Given that active policing varies by social group (Davenport, Soule, and Armstrong 2011; Medel and Somma 2022), and that group identities shape attitudes toward police violence (Reinka and Leach 2017), future studies could explore whether support for violent responses depends on who is involved. Since support for protests also varies by perceived legitimacy of claims (Passini and Morselli 2015) and tactics (Hsiao and Radnitz 2020), researchers might test how different demands and methods affect attitudes toward police violence. Finally, variation in treatment effects by distance suggests the need to account for differences between metropolitan and smaller-settlement residents (Simmel 2023).

Endnotes

1. Our definition of protest policing aims to measure active actions; it does not differentiate between legitimate and illegitimate forms, which is beyond the scope of this study.
2. The US Capitol riots on January 6, 2021, illustrate that right-wing groups can confront police forces. However, such instances are rare in Latin America. The military dictatorships of the 1970s and 1980s, supported by right-wing forces, have fostered a lasting inclination within the political right to prioritize social order and endorse state coercion. Consistent with this, right-leaning Latin Americans exhibit significantly greater trust in the police than centrists or leftists, even after controlling for individual and country-fixed effects (Ferreira da Silva et al. 2023).
3. Although protests continued into early 2020 before the pandemic, this analysis only considers events up to December 2019, as the spatialized protest data we utilize only covers events until that month.
4. Unlike Xu and Guo (2023), who use a canonical DiD with propensity score matching, our approach employs advanced DiD estimators that relax key assumptions, offering a more robust analysis of the attitudinal effects of active protest policing.
5. The analysis includes only respondents who participated in both the third (2018) and fourth (2019) waves of the ELSOC survey, excluding those present in only one wave or with missing data. The larger third-wave sample reflects a refreshment sample, which is excluded since it lacks responses in both waves. Thus, differences in sample sizes across waves do not affect results. The same logic applies to placebo tests using the second (2017) and third (2018) waves, which include only individuals surveyed in both.
6. A key bias affecting our research design is the underreporting of passive protest policing. Passive policing—such as monitoring, maintaining order, and negotiating—is subtle and typically goes unrecorded by newspapers. As Rafail, Soule, and McCarthy (2012, 745) note, “it is difficult, if not impossible, to reliably code information on negotiations between protestors and the police from newspaper records.” Consequently, like all protest event datasets we know, ours lacks an unbiased measure of passive policing. In contrast, we do capture direct measures of active policing – what Davenport, Soule, and Armstrong (2011, 157) call the “hard facts of an event (...) generally accurately covered by newspapers.”
7. Our independent variable is coded as “1” if the protest involved active policing—defined as physical altercations, police use of tear gas or water cannons, firearms, or detentions. These interactions are captured in the COES Conflict Observatory through variables P22a–P22d.

If none are present, the variable is coded “0,” covering protests with passive policing, no police presence, or no nearby protests. The database does not indicate whether policing was justified or unprovoked—a limitation shared by all protest event datasets, not just ours.

8. Distinguishing protests with and without active policing is challenging, especially with media-based data. However, our coding scheme mitigates this by relying on clear, objective indicators—such as police intervention or violent encounters with protesters—to identify active policing.
9. Only 0.3% of the sample did not respond to this question in 2019, indicating that it is not a particularly sensitive item.
10. We use trust in the police.
11. Measured using a question about respondents’ most valued social movement, which we turned into a variable with three categories: the student movement (11.7% of valid responses), another movement (53.4%), and none (34.9%).
12. Based on a scale using three items in the ELSOC questionnaire ($\alpha = 0.8$)
13. Based on a scale using two items in the ELSOC questionnaire ($\alpha = 0.8$)
14. For full results, see model 1 in Table A1 of the Appendix.
15. Our main models use proximity to at least one protest with active policing as a clear indicator of exposure. However, treating all protest frequencies equally may understate treatment effects, as noted by a reviewer. We therefore also analyze proximity to more than three and more than five such protests, corresponding to the 90th and 95th percentiles within a six-kilometer, two-week window. As shown in Figure A1 (Appendix), these alternative measures yield larger significant effects, suggesting that higher protest intensity increases support for violence against the police.
16. The most recent Origin–Destination Survey for Santiago—Chile’s largest city—dates back to 2012, and no more recent data are available to update commuting patterns nationwide.
17. However, we lack direct evidence that protests occurred near respondents’ workplaces or schools. While commuting patterns offer a plausible explanation, further research is needed to fully understand these dynamics.
18. For full results, see Table A2 in the Appendix.
19. We thank one of our anonymous reviewers for suggesting this interpretation of centrists.

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Conflicts of interest

None declared.

Data availability

Replication data and code are available in the Harvard Dataverse (Disi Pavlic et al. 2025).

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